My wife and I are shocked by the calumnies against us. We are accused of corruption and self-enrichment at the expense of the people. But Margot and I have nothing to reproach ourselves with; we did not lead a life of luxury and we do not have a bank account in Switzerland … I receive DM510 a month, from my trade as a roofer, and I have been informed that I am entitled to a further DM1,700 as a pension for having been in the anti-Nazi resistance. [The money was paid into Margot's bank account.] My own account is blocked, and I don't know when I will be able to touch it.

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(This public accusation of corruption – one newspaper accused him of raiding the country's treasury – struck him profoundly).

Finally, on 1 December, reunified German authorities issued an arrest warrant for Honecker on charges that he gave shoot-to-kill orders at the Berlin Wall. According to Wolfgang Ziegler, one of his lawyers, Honecker was 'very composed' when he received the news. However, he was shaken to learn German police had arrived at Beelitz to arrest him (the Soviets refused to hand him over). From here on in, the saga became a murky matter. On 7 March, another of Honecker's lawyers, Friedrich Wolff, met him at Beelitz where he thought he looked 'worse than ever before: swollen face and oedema in his legs. He has had problems with his intestines for three weeks.'25

Then suddenly, as German authorities pushed for his arrest, Erich and Margot were illicitly spirited to Russia on a Soviet military postal plane in a cloak-and-dagger operation. In Moscow, they were met by an ambulance, and transferred to Sokolniki hospital. It all happened so fast that staff in Beelitz only discovered the news about their sudden departure on television.